

Viruses—Literally!

Many Afghans switched off their mobiles as rumours spread that a deadly virus could be caught by answering calls from strange numbers. Supposedly, answering a call from a strange number would cause blood to ooze from the nose and ears, and one would die!



Free Cab Rides For Londoners

Microsoft is running a scheme for London workers who live in Tube zones 1 and 2; commuters will be able to catch any cabs—for free—that are labelled with the Microsoft Office logo between 7:30 and 9:30 in the morning. Go figure!



Escape

ARE PRESENTATIONS WORTH IT?

Less Power To The Point

Of course Microsoft and Google rule the world, but little things here and there keep reinforcing the fact. Take this for instance: a not-overly-famous researcher at the University of New South Wales publishes a not-so-groundbreaking paper on cognition, and it gets heavily publicised. Just because Professor Sweller said, “The use of the PowerPoint presentation has been a disaster. It should be ditched.” Note the use of the word “PowerPoint”; he didn’t use the generic “presentation application.” He did what’s not done: criticise the use of a Microsoft product.

To begin at the beginning: Prof John Sweller—who specialises in cognitive research—theorised and discovered that people cannot digest information properly when

it comes in two different forms, spoken and written. To quote the professor, “It is effective to speak to a diagram, because it presents information in a different form. But it is not effective to speak the same words that are written, because it is putting too much load on the mind and decreases your ability to understand what is being presented.”

Come to think of it, why *do* people present something on a projected screen and reiterate it by saying the same thing? What’s the Point (pun very much intended)? It’s probably (to the best of our understanding) what is known in educational circles as a pedagogical device that relies on reinforcement. Sweller is now saying that it doesn’t work, and that it should be done away with.

It’s been done for so long now, preparing neat PowerPoint slides and

delivering spiel. Think of that oft-repeated phrase, “I need to deliver this presentation”. Nice, bulleted points. Fonts. Heading styles. Borders. Etc. And all for naught? That’s exactly what Sweller is saying. Imagine all the (implied) lost productivity; and imagine the idea that there’s not much Power in the Point after all. (We couldn’t resist.)

OK, so this is just one professor’s work, but what if the idea were to gain momentum... would it mean the end of all those fonts and bulleted points? The end of the way execs and their minions do things every boring business day?

Perhaps we’re putting our feet in our mouths, because we’re toying with the idea of a *Fast Track to PowerPoint...* OK, so we’ll tell you the trick: do use the fancy fonts and all! They’ll get the Point across! Just don’t bother speaking when the slide is on! Save your breath and don’t mess with the cognitive faculties of your captive audience...

Whatever Happened To...

iSmell

Few products literally stink, but this one did—or at least it would have, had it progressed beyond the prototype stage.

In 1999, DigiScents Inc. developed a concept called iSmell, which allowed folks to get their noses as involved in their Web experience as their eyes and ears.

The iSmell Personal Scent Synthesizer was a shark-fin-shaped gizmo that plugged into a USB



port and wafted appropriate scents as you browsed smell-enabled Web sites—like Flowers.com, as a typical example. But sceptical users turned up their noses at the idea, making the iSmell the ultimate in vapourware.

The idea is just plain silly: imagine being not only assaulted by horrible MIDI files and pop-up ads, but also wafting aromas on the Web!

If you know the Web at all, you’d know this was a frightening prospect. Imagine going to the Jockey underwear site and... well, you get the drift!

We’re also not sure what DigiScents was thinking (or smoking) when they came up with the name: no-one would want to say “iSmell” out loud...

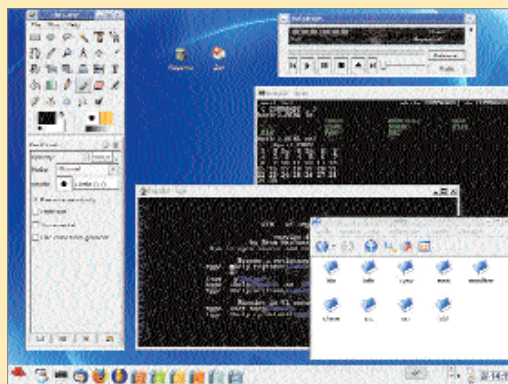
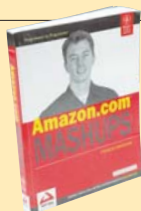
Win! My Desktop

Last month’s winner is
Dr Shivam Maini, Kanpur
How he did it:

1. Hack uxtheme.dll to change the start menu
 2. Crystal XP icons
 3. Classic window view for explorer
 4. Bluecurve 4.3 theme from Belchfire
 5. Digital Timepiece 3.0.94 for the clock
 6. Bash and Vim for Windows
- ...and this completes his uncanny Linux obsession. Congratulations!

Participate in this contest and win next month
Amazon.com MASHUPS
by Francis Shanahan
Published by

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Send in your Desktop with a description of how you made it to mydesktop@thinkdigit.com with the subject “My Desktop”, and tell us your postal address, too.